Adulting?

Design Doc

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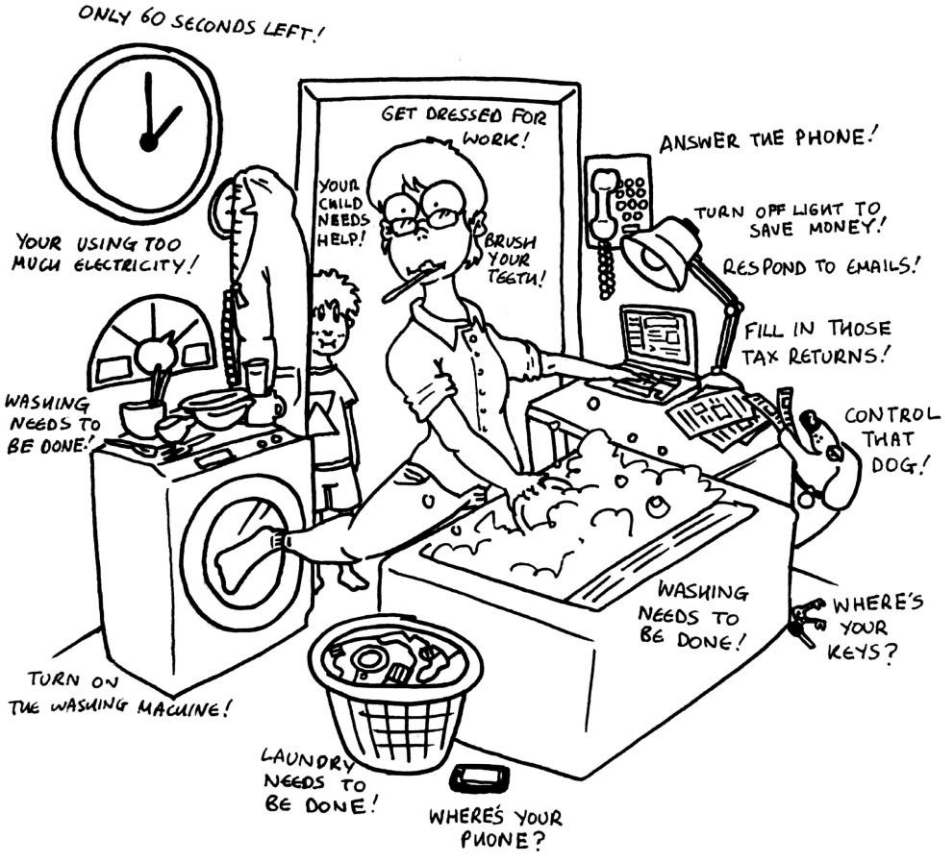


Figures 1. *Some early concept art for the game.*

Project Overview

Being an adult requires a lot from you, make sure you keep on top of all that work!

Adulting? is a single player game that requires the player to take on the role of a parent and homemaker represented through a series of mini-games within a one minute period. The player must navigate through a large (approx 10m x 10m space) and keep on top of the 3 chores placed in the corners of the area. The chores include filling in a tax return form, hoovering and running a bath. In addition, the playerspace includes a live actor, playing the role of a child, who talks about their day for the entire 60 second playthrough.

The experience is designed to overwhelm the player, emphasised through the sounding of different alarms (when the bath fills and when the dust level is unbearable), the playing of atmospheric music and the relatively large distance needed to be managed by the player.

Project Goal: Give the player an experiential outcome from a physically demanding game.

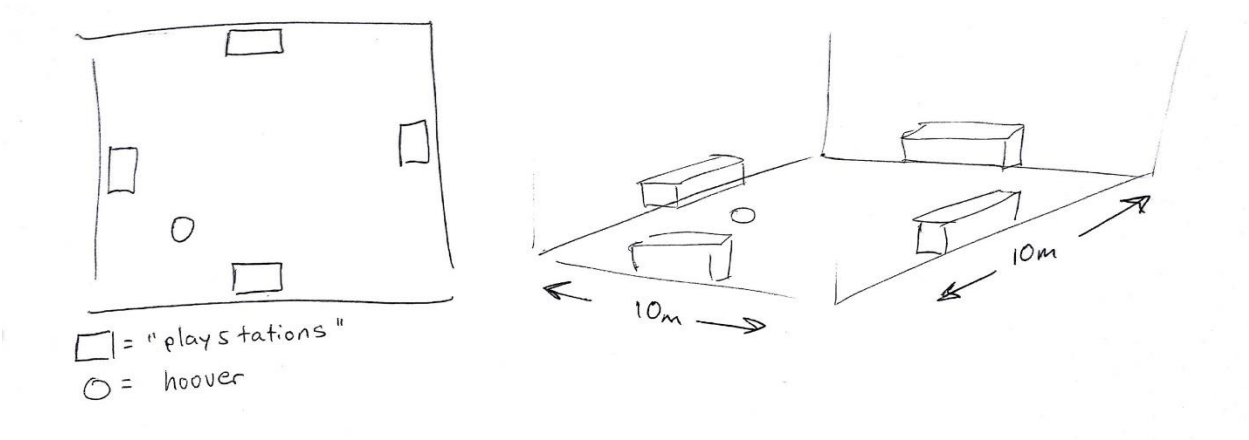


Figure 2. *Initial sketches of playspace. Boxes represent 3 mini-games and child.*

Design Values

PHYSICALITY
We wanted the game to have high-energy physical input that is hilarious for both player and viewer. We will spread the different 'playstations' across the playspace, so players must run between them. The minigames will have chore-themed inputs. The player will dress up in an apron and washing up gloves.

GALLERY GAME
The game will only work as installation, rather than game that can be played from home, due to the emphasis on space and physicality.

CHAOS
The player will inhabit an 'ever-shifting state of chaos'. There will be constant time pressure, with a time limit of 60 seconds and many tasks to complete that are consistently demanding the player's executive attention.

ACCEPTANCE OF LOSS
The game is like life; you won't always do well or win. In fact, this game is designed as a struggle - against time, and against the amount of work that the player must complete in that time. Their score will be tracked, but only to emphasise this.

WHAT REALLY MATTERS?
The game asks players to assess what they prioritise in their life, and whether some tasks, no matter how immediate they seem, are really as important as others. Upon the games conclusion, the player is presented with a score but following that, they are faced with a rhetorical question 'But what about your child…?'. We decided to leave the player with that rather than presenting them with actual questions as it prompts them to reflect on their performance after playing the game. Additionally, we felt that leaving the player without a way to answer reinforces that the game time (60 seconds) has been and gone as well as has the time for action from the player.

Basic Game Elements

Adulting? is a single player game. The goal of the player is potentially not initially understood. When the player enters the play space, every aspect of the game pushes them to understand that their role is to keep on top of the mini games, and that is important.

The main actions of the game consist of the player needing to complete their adult chores:

- **HOOVER.** The player must clean the floor with a physical vacuum nozzle attached to a bluetooth mouse, but their focus is on a screen to find where the dirt is
- **TAX RETURNS.** The player fills out a tax return on a screen by selecting from multiple choice answers - these are chosen by hitting a corresponding key on the keyboard.
- **BATH.** The player stops the water level of the bath from overflowing on a screen by pressing a spacebar on a keyboard.
- **CHILD.** The player may interact with a child that will be seeking attention from the player.

Physical objects the player interacts with include:

- **KEYBOARD.** A covered up windows keyboard with only the spacebar exposed for the Bath minigame.
- **WIRELESS MOUSE.** Attached at the end of a hoover nozzle used for the Hoover minigame.
- **NUMBER PAD.** Used to select multiple choice answers for the Tax Return minigame.

Minigame: Hoover

Gameplay Description: Players are faced with a screen rapidly filling up with dirt (shown as individual sprites, spawning every second). The player must use a hoover (their cursor) to suck up all the dirt so the floor is nice and clean! The game is made more complicated by the fact the mouse is attached to the end of a physical vacuum cleaner nozzle, making controlling the cursor on screen trickier.

Scoring: The player scores points for each dirt sprite hoovered up. It is possible to score highly by doing this, but this would neglect the other minigames.

Additional Design Considerations:

- We need to ensure the dirt doesn't spawn too fast so as to prevent the player from ever being able to leave the station unattended.
- If the screen gets too full, or the player doesn't hoover up dirt for a while, play a siren to prompt them to return.

Minigame: Tax Returns

Gameplay Description: The player must complete their tax returns by answering a never-ending list of humorous multiple choice questions. Each question can be answered with a different key press, but the key presses are randomised after each question to prevent the player from easily skipping through the questions.

Scoring: The player is awarded points for each question answered. There are no correct answers, but the form never ends, meaning the player can earn a high score (although this will again mean they neglect other minigames).

Additional Design Considerations:

- If the player doesn't answer a question after five seconds, play a siren to prompt them to answer again.
- Can we lock the player out of answering questions if they dally for too long? Perhaps they are automatically signed out of the form…

Minigame: Bath

Gameplay Description: The player is running a bath, and they must ensure it doesn't overflow by periodically returning to press a button. Simple, but when combined with the requirements of the other games it is easy to forget! The water level of the bath is represented on screen slowly rising, and the button the player's press to 'reset' the water level is built into a plastic child's bath.

Scoring: The player starts with 5000 points. Whenever the water level is 'overflowing' the player begins to lose points. This can continue until they have 0 points left, meaning the player is required to return to the minigame regularly.

Additional Design Considerations:

- As with other games, this will need a siren to sound to alert the player they must return when the bath is overflowing. Maybe the sound of water?
- We will need to balance the speed of the water rising to ensure the player has time to get to the other minigames.

Minigame: Child

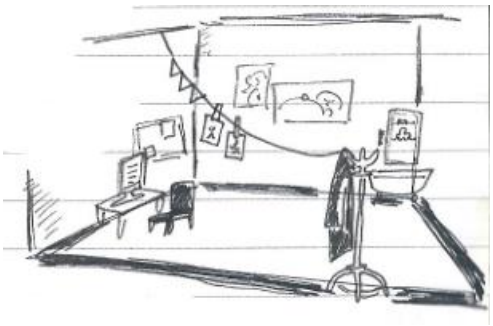
Gameplay Description: This part of the game is unique, as it involves a real actor playing the part of the child that is constantly vying for the attention of the player. The child will use visual stimulae, from their play area and around the room, to improvise conversation with the player. The player can choose to engage with the child or not.

Scoring: There are no points available for engaging with the child. This might lead the player to prioritise the other minigames. However, at the end of the game the player is faced with the message – 'what about your child?' Spending quality time with their child was what they should have prioritised.

Additional Design Considerations:

- We could prepare scripts for the actor playing the child, although these would be difficult to stick to if the player decided to interact heavily. Must ensure the room is decked out with prompt materials.
- How can we best get the message across through the child? Should they approach the player at the end of the game to give them a 'child's score' depending on how well they did in the eyes' of the child? Could the player be asked to answer questions about what the child was talking about with them?

Playspace



The playspace consists of a corner of a room, inside a sheltered building. The environment is set-dressed to create the ambience of a household using items such as a floor rug, bunting, a coat rack and childrens' toys, which also carries across into into the design of the 'playstations' that house the minigames.

The space is demarcated by the 'playstations' in each corner and the blanket / carpet.

This space is wide enough to give the player decent travel distance between each 'playstation'. This is important as the player has a sixty second playtime that in tandem with the alarms triggered by the minigames influence them to move faster.

Figure 3 & 4. *A mood board and (above) sketch of the playspace*

Player Experience

The player takes on sixty seconds of an adult amidst a series of imminent deadlines
They have the freedom to respond to the situation accordingly.
The environment is designed to influence stress through a lack of control over it.

The game's themes include:
Balancing life, learning to listen, quick thinking and decision making.

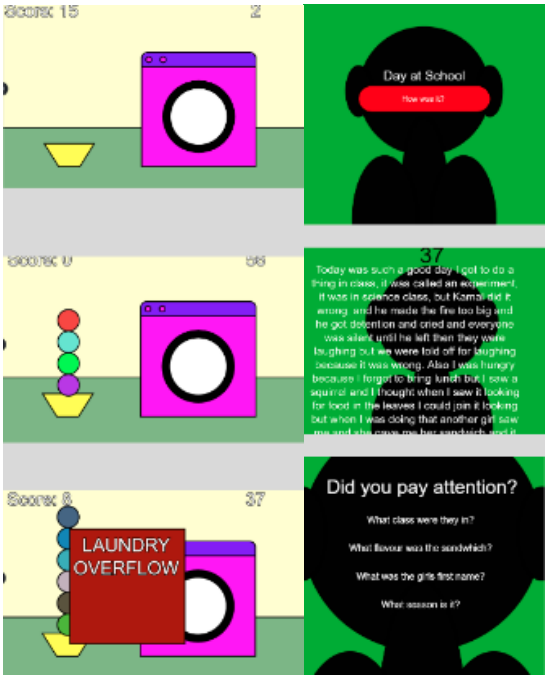
Point of view is given from the perspective of a working parent. They receive immediate feedback from their environment - alarms go off if their chores are left undone and all the while their child is trying to communicate with them. The player feels overwhelmed with their attention being diverted to multiple sources simultaneously.

Figures 5. *The final start screen of the game*

There is physical challenge presented from the time restriction and continuous tasks to fulfil across the space. The decision-making comes from them deciding what to focus their time on. Skill is a deciding factor if the player is good at a minigame, and can come into play whether they can move quickly between stations. Owing to the experiential nature of the game, observing players may form strategies, while the technical crew and actor will add elements of chance by keeping an improvised dialogue and the chance of an unexpected additional third person.

Adulting? could theoretically be played by anyone, but each player would encounter different restrictions. Emotions could range from frustration from a lack of time to overwhelmed by the abundance of tasks to do.

Project Process Documentation



Figures 6 & 7. *First versions of the mini games (laundry and child) running through p5.js. These ran on seperate computers and each needed to be started individually and no combined score was gathered.*

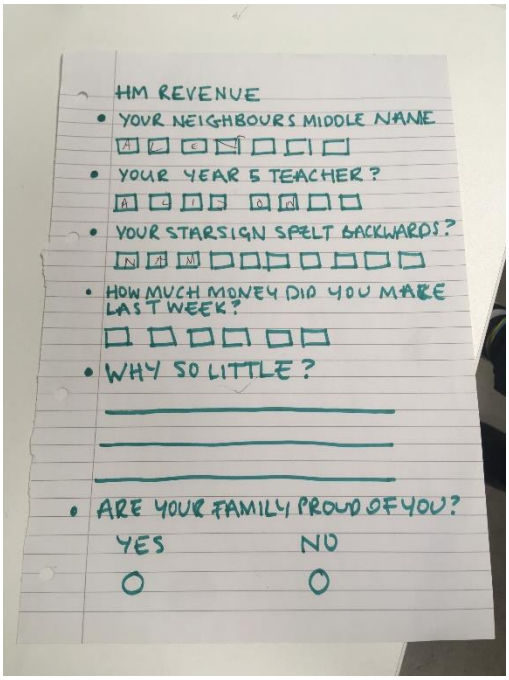


Figure 8. *Original draft of the mock Tax Return form partially filled by a playtester.*

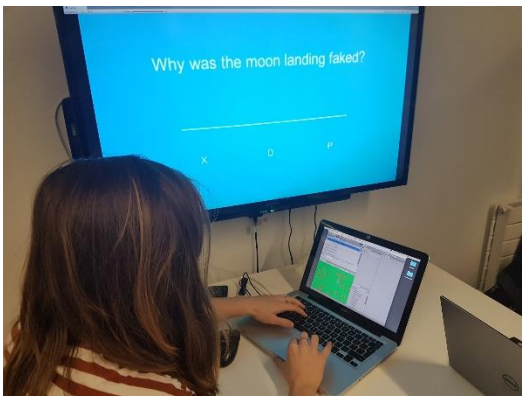


Figure 9. *Testing first version of multiple games with different display monitors.*
Figure 10. *An early playtester dashing between play stations.*

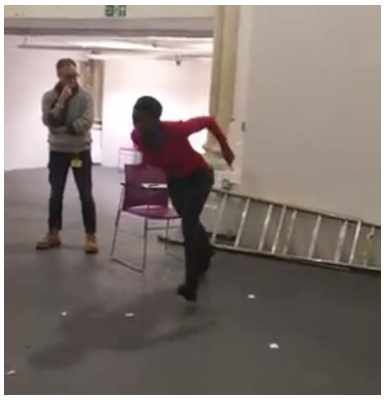


Figure 11. *Image of the playspace with child*

Figure 12. *A fully working internal playtest*

	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4	WEEK 5		XMAS	WEEK 6 - Part 1	WEEK 6 - Part 2		FINAL WEEK
MEETING	7th - 13th (Reading Week)	13th - 20th	20th - 27th	27th - 4th	4th - 11th	11th - 18th	11th - 31st	31st - 7th	7th - 10th	14th	15th
AGENDA	Plan Presentation	Configure a rough playable prototype	Meeting focused on Child script Play Overcooked on Switch	Show minigames progress Stock Equipment Start state Discuss art style Mario Party	~~Put into one Unity Project~~ *Documentation*	Finish Bath Minigame Put all into a single Unity Project Plan who gets what for playspace ~~Check out Dryeland Markers?~~	Time off	**Whole day session** Put elements all together Book Equipment from Uni *Documentation*	**Whole day session** Collect Booked Equipment - 9:30AM Setup, create and test the playspace **Take pictures for Documentation**	**Additional Session** Woking with Pete from Computing to help us fix issues **Take pictures for Documentation**	Practicing set up/ get materials/decide on space Playtest with people who haven't played **Take pictures for documentation**
Ideas Discussed	Ideas on multiple displays Data Baby	Screen in toy washing machine Unity and multiple displays Tax Forms: simple written version? (final vers) multiple choice? More physical games? Need to decide mini games - decide ones we will take - can you do multiple sounds from multiple monitors - surround sound? Storage Space Gantt Chart (for setting time specific goals) Minigames to have quasi-journal style logs Blowing on bath (which blows bubbles) Created timeline	See: *Child Meeting - 27/11/2018*	Boxing day sales Pre-Crimbo decide who will source what props Post-Crimbo purchase props / build set pieces Start Screen All screens have a to do list (everywhere the parent looks, they are reminded of what they have to do) Art Style: Plain background colour (Pastel w/ primary coloured objects) Mario Party - Waluigi (George) Win	*Meeting called off for work on assignments*	*See: Pre-Xmas Meeting - 18/12/2018*		See: *Post-Xmas Meeting - 07/01/2019*	- Full tech setup and test - Screens are very large, potentially a smaller one for tax returns - Need additional extension leads - HDMI splitter USB powersource - USB to HDMI - Playspace setup and test - Playtest NEED: - Furnishings for wall of playspace (drawings etc) - String to hang above ceiling of playspace	Bugs: - Title Screen and Countdown needs flipping on Bath Screen - Bath goes off centre after hitting box collider - Hoover cannot clean bottom of screen on larger monitor - Tax Return can't handle fast user inputs - Mashing SPACE can skip endscreen and go back to title screen - Tax Return (disregard choice) *Child ver2.0:* Actor leaves after 60s *Player* left with message - High Score: 15550	
LESSON	14th - PRESENTATIONS	20th - PROTOTYPE 1	27th - QUESTIONS	4th - PROGRESS REPORT	11th	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	15th - BRING IN A PLAYABLE GAME (w/ Slideshow)
Feedback	Keep the child story Bath overflow is a more immediate objective Papooose - obstruction of baby (spoken text - raised pitch? audio + visual?)	See: *Playtest Feedback - 20/11/2018*	Q: "Actor or Audio/Visual Child?" A: "I need to see it" Solution: keep working on it	Rede: "Focus on the creation of the space" Google Home - a 'nice to have' Jamie: Child hoover, that actually hoovers, but with playful sounds	*In conversation w/ Phearox:* Maintain look of child - shave, clothing? **Tax Return**: make it look like tax return - make the choices "look like keys" you have to press - "mock the format" Hoovering: "fix this shit" (regarding mousedrag) **Graphics**: "Simify the art style" **Space**: "demarcate the space" / map out playspace (a rug, quadrents influenced by play stations... etc) **Player**: coat rack, for player customisation						
TASKS	Prepare for Presentation	Get familiar with Unity	Continue minigames for showing next week	Finish minigames for merge next week	Finish minigames, bring broken hoover	Finish minigames	Try to Relax	Brief 3-5 Slide Presentation	Brief 3-5 Slide Presentation	Finish Documentation	

Figure 13. *Task management sheet recording the process from week to week*